

Sikun Xu

CONTACT INFORMATION	Knight Hall 401 Olin Business School Washington University in St. Louis	<i>Phone:</i> +1 (646) 384-9865 <i>E-mail:</i> sikun@wustl.edu <i>Website:</i> https://sikunxu.com
RESEARCH INTERESTS	<i>Methodology:</i> Machine Learning and AI Systems, Causal Inference, Data-Driven Decision-Making <i>Application:</i> Quantitative Marketing, Quantitative Finance	
EDUCATION	Washington University in St. Louis • Ph.D. Candidate, Olin Business School 2021–Present • Advisors: Dennis Zhang and Raphael Thomadsen Columbia University in the City of New York • M.S. in Operations Research 2019–2020 Shanghai Jiao Tong University • B.S. in Industrial Engineering 2015–2019	
WORKING PAPERS	1. A Causal Approach to Representation Learning for Unstructured Data, with Zhenling Jiang, Zhengling Qi, and Dennis Zhang. <i>Major revision at Management Science</i>. 2. The Winner’s Curse in Data-Driven Decision-Making: Evidence and Solutions, with Raphael Thomadsen and Dennis Zhang. <i>Submitted</i>.	
CONFERENCE PROCEEDINGS	1. Xu, Sikun, Ruoyi Ma, Daniel K. Molzahn, Hassan Hijazi, and Cédric Jozs. “Verifying global optimality of candidate solutions to polynomial optimization problems using a determinant relaxation hierarchy.” In 2021 60th IEEE Conference on Decision and Control (CDC), pp. 3143-3148. IEEE, 2021.	
WORK IN PROGRESS	1. SOTA or Luck? The Winner’s Curse in LLM Leaderboards, with Heng Zhang, Raphael Thomadsen, and Dennis Zhang.	
INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE	• Machine Learning Scientist Intern, TikTok Inc., San Jose 2026–Present • Co-founder and Consultant, Ask2.AI, New York 2022–Present • Quantitative Researcher, Sauma Capital LLC, New York 2021 • Investment Intern, Capstone Investment Advisors, New York 2020 • Algorithm Engineer Intern, Cardinal Operations, Shanghai 2018	

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Guest Lecturer

- MGT 680E AI & Machine Learning Business Applications, Washington University in St. Louis Fall 2024
- IEOR 4721 AI Application in Finance, Columbia University Spring 2022
- IEOR 4721 AI Application in Finance, Columbia University Summer 2021

Teaching Assistant

- Olin Business School, Washington University in St. Louis
 - MGT 680E AI & Machine Learning Business Applications
 - SCOT 519E Revenue Management
 - SCOT 500M Supply Chain Analytics: Stochastic Models
 - SCOT 558 Advanced Operations Strategy
 - SCOT 5704 Operations Management
 - SCOT 356 Operations and Manufacturing Management
 - SCOT 400D Supply Chain Management
 - SCOT 500D Project Management
- Columbia University in the City of New York
 - IEOR 4742 Deep Learning
 - IEOR 4525 Machine Learning

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

The Winner's Curse in Data-Driven Decision-Making: Evidence and Solutions

- INFORMS Annual Meeting, Atlanta, GA 2025
- ISMS Marketing Science Conference, Washington, D.C. 2025
- Conference on Artificial Intelligence, Machine Learning, and Business Analytics, New Haven, CT 2024

A Causal Approach to Representation Learning for Unstructured Data

- ISMS Marketing Science Conference, Washington, D.C. 2025
- INFORMS Annual Meeting, Seattle, WA 2024
- POMS Annual Conference, Minneapolis, MN 2024
- INFORMS Annual Meeting, Phoenix, AZ 2023

Data Driven Security Selection for Wealth Management

- POMS Annual Conference, Orlando, FL 2023
- INFORMS Annual Meeting, Indianapolis, IN 2022

Verifying Global Optimality of Candidate Solutions to Polynomial Optimization Problems Using a Determinant Relaxation Hierarchy

- INFORMS Annual Meeting, Anaheim, CA 2021

ACADEMIC SERVICE

- Reviewer: *Journal of Investment Strategies*
- Session Chair: INFORMS Annual Meeting

Last updated: May 2026